Manosphere and the Role of Masculinity

Rationality Freiburg

Catarina & Omar

2026-07-03

Setting the frame

A frame for tonight

- Why this topic matters
- What has changed around masculinity?
- Why do some men look for answers online?
- What do these spaces offer, and what worries people?
- What could better support look like?

Goal: understand the needs, the risks, and the alternatives.

Changing roles, unclear expectations

- Men are less often expected to be only “the provider”
- Men are more often encouraged to talk about emotions
- Dating and relationship norms feel less clear than before
- Gender roles have shifted for women and men alike
- Online culture increasingly shapes how people learn about gender and dating

Different people experience this differently

- Some men feel lonely, rejected, blamed, or unsure of their role
- Some women feel unsafe, dismissed, or objectified
- Some people feel hopeful about changing gender roles
- Some feel the conversation has become too polarized

No one person speaks for their whole gender.

Understanding the manosphere

What is “the manosphere”?

A broad mix of online spaces about men, dating, status, and gender.

- Self-improvement, fitness, money, confidence
- Dating and relationship advice
- Men’s rights discussions
- Red Pill / MGTOW spaces
- Incel forums
- Podcasts, coaches, influencers

Why it's hard to summarize

- Some content is practical
- Some content is angry
- Some content is harmful
- Often, all three are mixed together

It is not one single group or belief system.

Why can it appeal?

- "Your problems are real"
- Clear explanations and rules
- Advice on dating, status, and success
- A feeling of belonging
- Language for rejection, shame, and loneliness

People are drawn in because something feels **missing**.

When support becomes risky

- Real pain can turn into blame
- Advice can become manipulation or control
- Generalizations start to feel normal
- Anger can become part of someone's identity
- Influencers can profit from insecurity

The concern isn't men supporting each other – it's support turning into **contempt**.

Discussing it well

A balanced way to discuss it

Separate three things:

- **Need** – what is the person looking for?
- **Story** – how are they explaining the problem?
- **Action** – what do they actually do next?

Take needs seriously, without agreeing with every story or action.

Small-group questions

Pick one. Use examples. Be curious about disagreement.

- What real needs do manosphere spaces respond to?
- What do critics get right – and sometimes miss?
- Where do manosphere explanations or solutions go wrong?
- What would healthy support for men look like in real life?

Try to leave with **one practical idea**.

Small actions

- Check in on someone who may be lonely or under pressure
- Tell a man in your life something you appreciate about him
- Make space for a more honest conversation
- Speak up when a joke feels unfair or cruel
- Invite someone to a real-world activity

How to talk tonight

- Be honest and kind
- Don’t treat anyone as a spokesperson for their gender
- Talk about ideas and actions, not people in the room
- Describe the other side fairly before criticizing it
- Leave space for uncertainty

Thank you – let’s discuss.